

iAPPLIED PROCESS ENGINEERING

GROUP-6

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1. ABSTRACT

The objective of this study is to design a continuous flow process capable of producing 50 tons/day of anhydrous ammonia using the Haber–Bosch process. Nitrogen is supplied from air, and hydrogen is generated via steam reforming of natural gas. The analysis applies material and energy balance principles to determine input and output requirements, recycle-purge specifications, and the operating conditions for each unit are specified in the flow diagram. Industrial practice shows that ammonia formation is favoured at high pressures (200 bar) and moderate temperatures (400-500°C), while an Fe-based catalyst is employed for enhancement of the reaction. A complete flow diagram was designed, including reactors, coolers, preheaters, and compressors. The material balances were carried out in kmol/day units while energy balances consider only for temperature changes. The final design achieves the target production rate of 50 tons of ammonia per day, requiring approximately 1430.8 kmol/day of natural gas for hydrogen generation and 2138.6 kmol/day of air for nitrogen supply. A recycle ratio of 4.5 and purge ratio of 2.25% were selected to limit accumulation of inert gases to maximise conversion in the synthesis loop. Secondary streams include CO₂ from reforming, vapour and unreacted gases (argon, CH₄) that appear in the purge stream. These by-products can be recovered and utilized as fuel gas or for water recovery. This design demonstrates a feasible approach for industrial-scale ammonia production.

2. INTRODUCTION

Ammonia is one of the most widely produced industrial chemicals worldwide. It is a key component in fertilizers, chemicals, and industrial processes. It is very useful on regular basis; despite having large usage, production of ammonia is complicated because of its

raw materials. Large-scale production of ammonia requires high efficiency, energy management, and safe operation. Optimizing operating conditions are crucial for the production [1].

There are different types of process for ammonia preparation. Industrially via the Haber–Bosch process reacting nitrogen with hydrogen at high pressure and temperature with an Iron catalyst. Other methods include the hydrolysis of metal nitrides and emerging green routes like electrochemical synthesis from nitrogen and water, aiming for more sustainable production [2].

The production of ammonia is generally dominated by Haber–Bosch process because it is highly optimized, economically feasible and kinetics using high pressure and moderate temperature (400 – 650°C), and iron catalyst, allowing large scale and continuous production. But the alternative methods struggle with economic feasibility and separation process. Carl Bosch scaled Fritz Haber's lab discovery, creating robust equipment for high pressures (150-400 atm) and integrating continuous recycling for maximum efficiency [3].

The Haber–Bosch process is the primary method for industrial ammonia synthesis. It involves reaction of nitrogen from air and hydrogen derived from natural gas under high pressure (200 bar), moderate temperature (400-500°C) with an Fe-based catalyst. Key process factors include recycle and purge ratios. This study focuses on the production of 50 tons/day of ammonia [4].

Objective of the report is to present a flow diagram representing complete ammonia production, also to analyse material, energy balances and operational conditions for maximum output.

The flow diagram starts with feed preparation from natural gas and air via desulfurizer, primary and secondary reformer, shift conversion. Then it is followed by gas purification and compression of N_2 and H_2 gases along with a flow control to maintain 1:3 ratio. It is followed by a cooler to obtain liquid ammonia.

3. ASSUMPTIONS

The following assumptions were made as per course instructions and for simplification of calculations:

- The process operates under steady-state and steady-flow conditions.
- All gaseous streams are assumed to behave as ideal gases throughout the process.
- Pressure drops in pipelines and heat exchangers are neglected.
- Energy balances consider only sensible heat changes due to temperature variation; reaction heat and shaft work are neglected as per project scope.

4. METHOD

4.a. PROCESS FLOW DIAGRAM EXPLANATION:

The overall ammonia production process is divided into several unit operations. The PFD includes all major equipment and the main material streams. Each unit is explained with operational conditions.

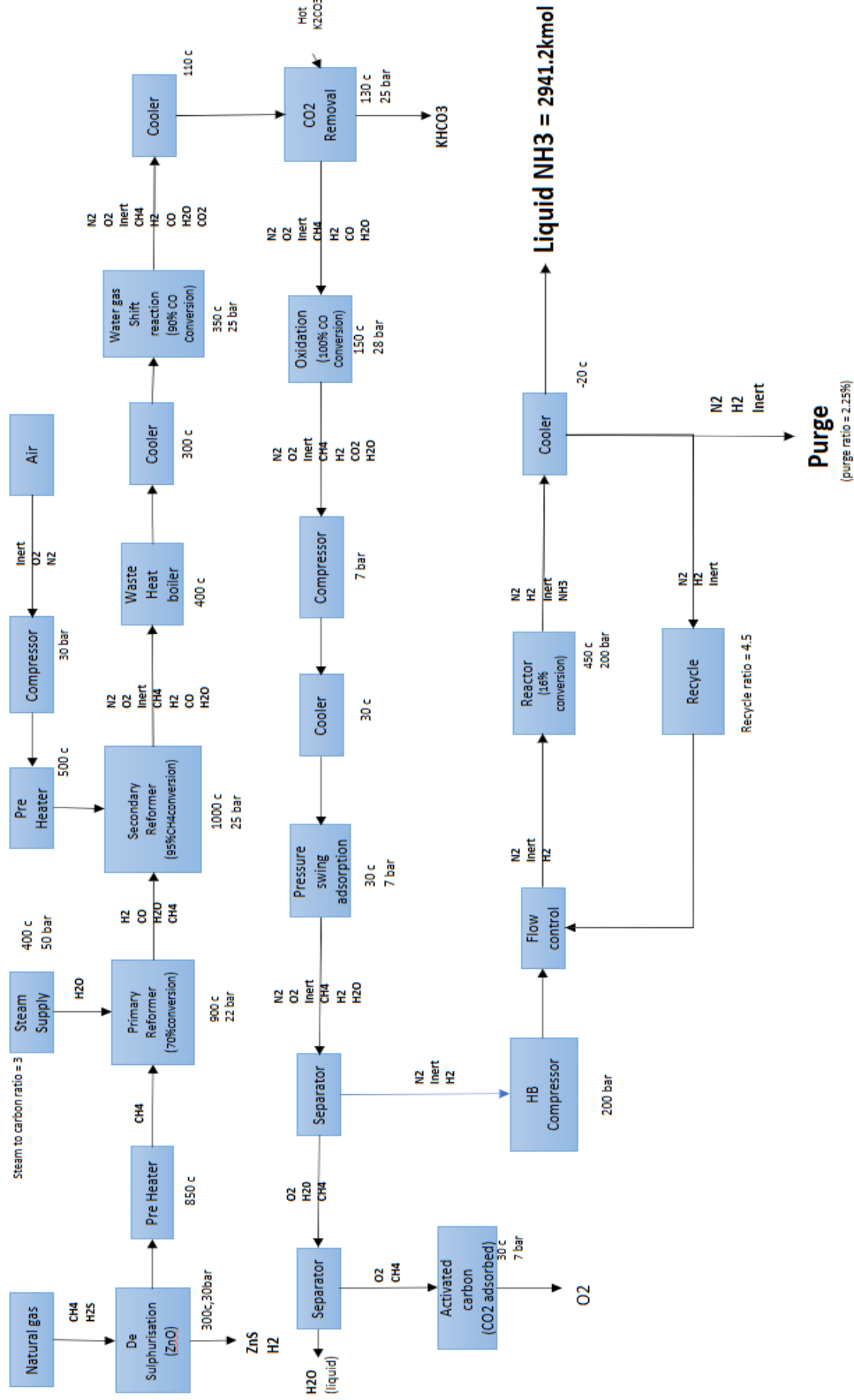


FIGURE 1: PROCESS FLOW DIAGRAM OF AMMONIA SYNTHESIS

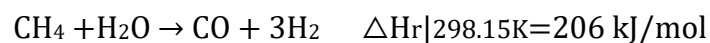
4.b. MAJOR UNITS IN PFD:

4.b.1. DESULFURIZER: Removes sulphur and its compounds from natural gas using zinc oxide beds. Because they act as catalyst poison in further reactions, so it is necessary to remove them. It is operated at 300°C, 30 bar [5].



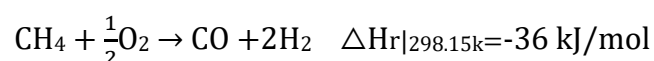
- A preheater is installed in between desulpharizer unit and primary reformer unit to raise the temperature of natural gas from 300°C to 850°C.

4.b.2. PRIMARY REFORMER: Sulphur free natural gas reacts with steam to produce CO and H₂ operates at 900°C, 22 bar. 70% single-pass conversion of natural gas is considered. A steam supply at 400°C, 50 bar and natural gas at 850°C are inputs for this unit [6].



- A preheater is installed to raise the temperature of air from room temperature (25°C) to 500°C.

4.b.3. SECONDARY REFORMER: The output of primary reformer (unreacted CH₄, H₂O, CO, H₂) are reacted with O₂ from air (N₂, O₂, Ar) and produces CO. Operates at 1000°C temperature and 25 bar pressure. A single-pass conversion of 95% of natural gas is considered. The inputs from primary reformer are at 900°C, the input from air are at 500°C, whereas the outputs are at 1000°C [7].



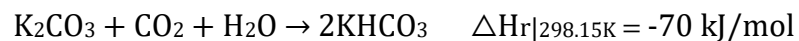
- A cooler is added to decrease the temperature from 1000°C to 350°C and passed as an input to water gas shift reaction.

4.b.4. WATER GAS SHIFT REACTION: The output of cooler becomes the input of shift reactor which operates at 350°C, 25 bar. A single-pass conversion of 95% is considered at this operating conditions [8].



- A cooler is added to further decrease the temperature from 350°C to 110°C to proceed with CO₂ removal

4.b.5. CO₂ REMOVAL: The output of cooler is passed on to the surface of K₂CO₃ for chemical adsorption to remove CO₂. Assumed that surface area is large enough and stream stays enough time so that all of CO₂ is absorbed by K₂CO₃ and converted into KHCO₃. Operates at 130°C [9].



4.b.6. OXIDATION: CO in the output of CO₂ removal gets oxidised to CO₂ by using the oxygen remaining from secondary reformer. Operates at 150°C temperature and 28 bar pressure. 100% oxidation of CO is assumed because of excess availability of O₂ [10].



- A cooler is installed to reduce the temperature from 150°C to 30°C so that CO₂ adsorbs by pressure swing adsorption process

4.b.7. PRESSURE SWING ADSORPTION: Physical adsorption of CO₂ takes place at 30°C temperature and 7 bar pressure. Removing of CO₂ is mandatory because it acts as poison if it passes into Haber–Bosch process reactor [11].

- Then after a separator is placed to separate N₂, H₂, inert gases from the remaining mixture. The remaining mixture is further separated using

various techniques and adsorption process to get O₂, H₂O and CH₄ and they act as energy fuels and raw products.

- The mixture of N₂, H₂, inert gases are sent into a compressor to compress from 7 bar to 200 bar. It is followed by a flow control to maintain a mole ratio of 1:3 for N₂, H₂ respectively and recycle stream mixes with the pure feed at this position [12].

4.b.8. REACTOR: The stream flow of N₂, H₂ and NH₃ flows into a reactor which operates at 450°C temperature and 200 bar pressure. A single-pass conversion of 16% is industrially approved and the output is flown into a cooler [13].



- A cooler decreases the temperature of stream from 450°C to -20°C. Phase transfer of NH₃ occurs in this range so that we separate liquid NH₃ from real gases.
- A part of the stream of remaining gases is recycled, and the remaining is sent out as purge to prevent the accumulation of inert gases. Recycle ratio of 4.5 is used with a purge percentage of 2.25%.
- Both material and energy balances are calculated in the excel sheet attached.
- Material balance is all calculated in kmole/day units whereas energy balance is done in kJ/s units

4.c. Cp values Table

The following table is used for energy balances assuming all gases are ideal throughout the process [14].

$$\sum \dot{n} C_p \Delta T = Q$$

The above equation is applied to all heat exchange units considering only sensible heat changes.

$C_p^{\text{ig}} / R = A + BT + C T^2 + D T^{-2}$ for $T(\text{K})$, $R = 8.314 \text{ J} \cdot \text{K}^{-1} \cdot \text{mol}^{-1}$, C_p units ($\text{J} \cdot \text{mol}^{-1} \cdot \text{K}^{-1}$)

Chemical species	A	$10^3 \cdot B$	$10^6 \cdot C$	$10^{-5} \cdot D$
CH ₄	1.702	9.081	-2.164	0
H ₂ S	3.931	1.490	0	-0.232
ZnO	45.91	9.089	4.159	-6.049
ZnS	43.11	12.658	-1.122	2.48
H ₂ O	3.47	1.45	0	0.121
CO	3.376	0.557	0	-0.031
H ₂	3.249	0.422	0	0.083
O ₂	3.639	0.506	0	-0.227
N ₂	3.28	0.593	0	0.04
inert	20.786	0.000123	-0.136	0
CO ₂	5.457	1.045	0	-1.157
NH ₃	29.75	0.00254	-1.226	7.55

TABLE 1: C_p VALUES TABLE

- Latent heat of condensation of H₂O: -40.7 kJ/mol.
- Latent heat of condensation of NH₃: -23.5 kJ/mol.

5. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The following flow charts represent the complete material balance and energy balance (accounted only for temperature changes).

- 2941.2 kmol of NH_3 per day is produced by following this flow design.
- To produce 50 tons of NH_3 per day we need 1430.8 kmol of natural gas, 2138.6 kmol of air and 4163.6 kmol of H_2O is required per day.
- There is a total energy change of 11584 kJ/s to produce 50 tons of NH_3 per day.
- The overall material and energy balance for the ammonia production provides detailed information about stream compositions, temperatures, pressures, and flow rates across each unit.
- The reactor feed stream contains a nitrogen to hydrogen ratio close to 1:3, while the reactor outlet stream contains both unreacted reactants and product ammonia.
- The liquid ammonia is obtained after cooling the product stream to -20°C temperature.
- It is an exothermic reaction. Due to thermodynamic limitations, the single pass of nitrogen remains relatively low (16%).
- This low conversion justifies the presence of a large recycle loop (recycle ratio 4.5), which improves the overall plant efficiency by returning unreacted N_2 and H_2 to the reactor.
- The purge stream ensures that inert gases do not accumulate in the system.

INPUT(KMOL/DAY)		OUTPUT(KMOL/DAY)	
NH ₃	0	NH ₃	2941.18
N ₂	1668.08	N ₂	214.23
O ₂	449.10	H ₂	642.66
H ₂ S	42.92	O ₂	217.2
CH ₄	1387.85	CH ₄	20.8
H ₂ O	4163.55	H ₂ O	594.7
K ₂ CO ₃	1298.68	K ₂ CO ₃	0
ZnO	42.92	KHCO ₃	2597.36
Inert	19.58	Inert	19.58

TABLE 2: MATERIAL BALANCE

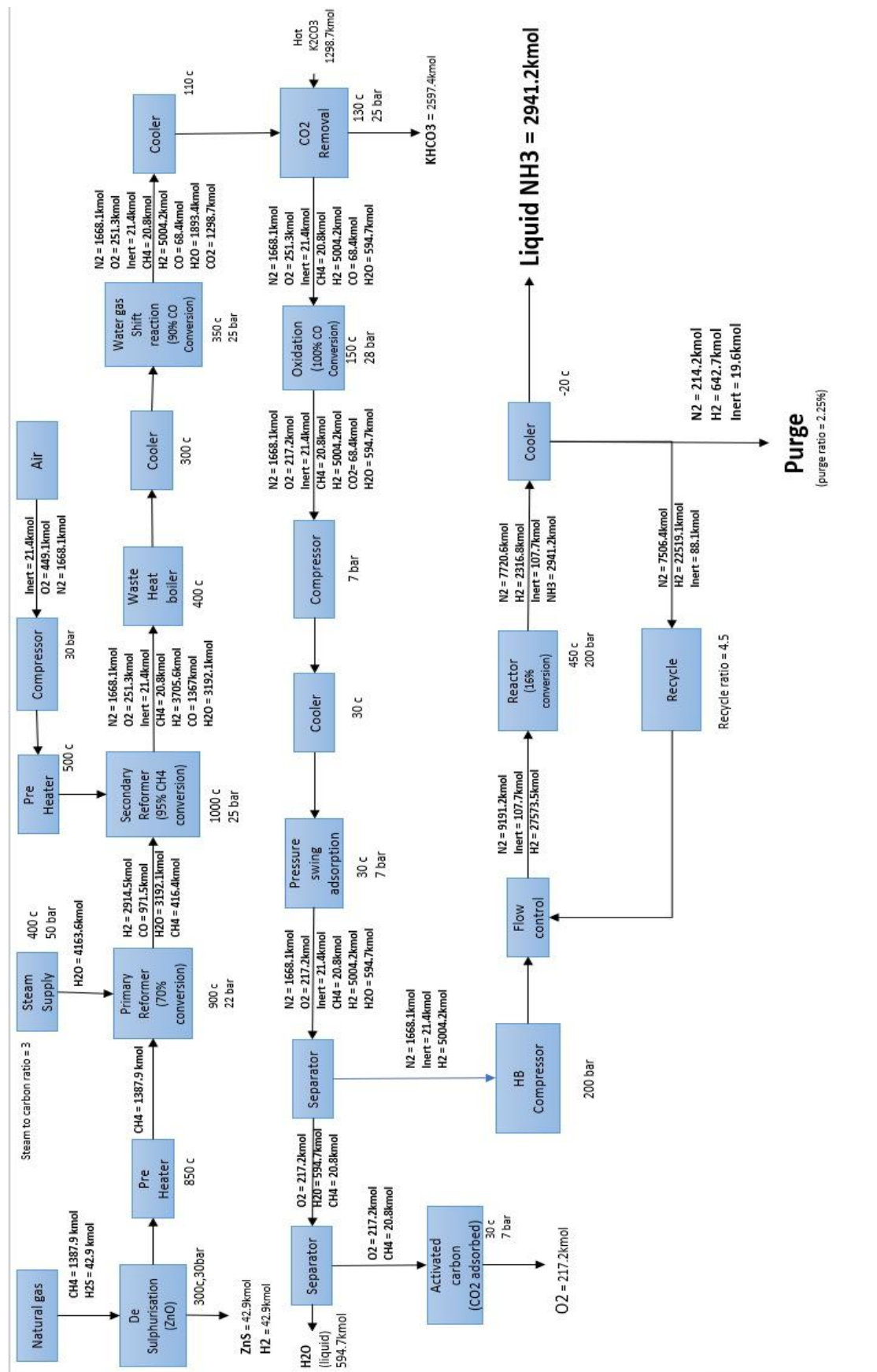


FIGURE 2- OVERALL MATERIAL BALANCE

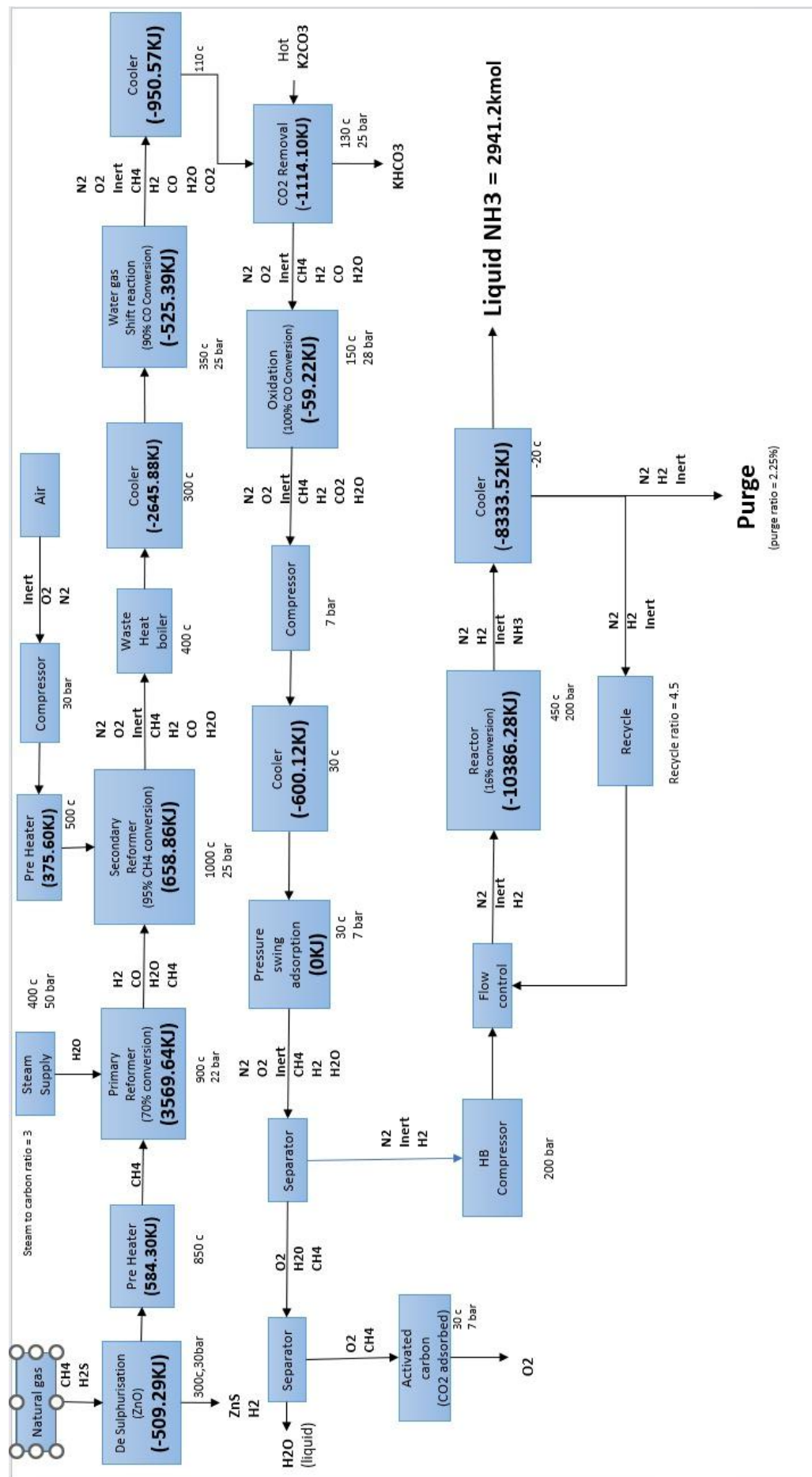


FIGURE 3- OVERALL ENERGY BALANCE(ONLY FOR TEMPERATURE CHANGE)

Sensitive analysis was performed to understand how the results vary with changes in operating conditions. When the reactor temperature was at 450°C, it is observed that lower temperature increases equilibrium by Le Chatlier's principle, but it decreases the rate of reaction. Changes in recycle ratio from 4.5 to 4 decreased the output significantly for same amount of feed, whereas increasing it from 4.5 to 5 increased the load on compressor.

6. CONCLUSION:

The purpose of this study is to design a model for synthesis of 50 tons of ammonia per day. It includes both material and energy balance (considered only for change in temperature). Assumed overall system is in steady flow and the temperatures and pressures are constant. The study shows that to produce 50 tons of ammonia, 1430.8 kmol of natural gas (95% purity is required), 4163.3 kmol of steam supply is required and 2138.6 kmol of air is required. 16% single pass conversion of Haber Bosch reactor is concluded for maximum formation of ammonia with a recycle ratio of 4.5. Although reaction mechanisms, fluid properties are not considered this study gives an overview of how material, energy balances are made and the assumptions made. A flow sheet is prepared enclosing all the work which is done.

7. CALUCULATIONS:

All material and energy balance calculations are done in the following excel sheet.

APE.xlsx

7.a. MATERIAL BALANCE:

NATURAL GAS		1430.773		DESULPHARISER					PRIMARY REFORMER			0.7	AIR	2138.564
				INPUT		OUTPUT			INPUT		OUTPUT			
	CH4	1387.85		CH4	1387.85	H2O	42.9232		H2O	4163.55	CH4	416.35	N2	1668.08
	H2S	42.9232		H2S	42.9232	ZnS	42.9232		CH4	1387.85	CO	971.5	O2	449.0985
				ZnO	42.9232	CH4	1387.85				H2	2914.5	INERT	19.58
											H2O	3192.05		
				e		42.9232			e		971.5			

	SECONDARY REFORM		0.95		WATER GAS SHIFT REACTION		0.95	CO2 REMOVAL			
INPUT	OUTPUT			INPUT	OUTPUT			INLET	OUTLET		
N2	1668.08	N2	1668.08	N2	1668.08	N2	1668.08	N2	1668.08	N2	1668.08
O2	449.0985	O2	251.3322	O2	251.3322	O2	251.3322	O2	251.3322	O2	251.3322
INERT	19.58	INERT	19.58	INERT	19.58	INERT	19.58	INERT	19.58	INERT	19.58
CH4	416.35	CH4	20.8175	CH4	20.8175	CH4	20.8175	CH4	20.8175	CH4	20.8175
CO	971.5	H2	3705.565	H2	3705.565	H2	5004.246	H2	5004.246	H2	5004.246
H2	2914.5	CO	1367.033	CO	1367.033	CO	68.35163	CO	68.35163	CO	68.35163
H2O	3192.05	H2O	3192.05	H2O	3192.05	H2O	1893.369	H2O	1893.369	H2O	594.6883
						CO2	1298.681	CO2	1298.681	KHCO3	2597.362
								K2CO3	1298.681	CO2	0
	e	395.5325		e	1298.681			e	1298.681		

[illegible]

REACTOR INLET		OUTLET			RECYCLE	4.5		PURGE			PRODUCT
N2	9191.176	N2	7720.588		N2	7506.36		N2	214.2282		NH3
H2	27573.53	H2	23161.76		H2	22519.11		H2	642.6583		2941.176
INERT	107.69	INERT	107.69		INERT	88.11		INERT	19.58		
		NH3	2941.176								
									876.4665		
						30025.47					
						670.76		inert percentage	0.02234		
	e	1470.588				0.97766					

7.b. ENERGY BALANCE:

[illegible]

SECONDARY REFORMER												
	delHr											
1173.15	-36											
	1.702	9.081	-2.164	0	-1489.25	-5.85E+03	1.15E+03	0	-6189.1	-247.96		
	3.376	0.557	0	-0.031	-2954	-3.59E+02	0.00E+00	-7.75499261	-3320.29	-310.395		
	3.249	0.422	0	0.083	-2842.875	-2.72E+02	0.00E+00	20.7633673	-3083.75	-867.652		
	3.47	1.45	0	0.121	-3036.25	-9.33E+02	0.00E+00	30.2694873	-3939.34	-1210.01	-2636.018106	
773.15												
	3.639	0.506	0	-0.227	-1728.525	-1.29E+02	0.00E+00	-46.7757643	-1904.04	-82.2839		
	3.28	0.593	0	0.04	-1558	-1.51E+02	0.00E+00	8.24242544	-1700.64	-272.976	-373.8255055	
	20.786	0.000123	-0.136	0	-9873.35	-3.13E-02	1.97E+01	0	-9853.63	-18.5654		
1273.15												
	3.28	0.593	0	0.04	3198	4.54E+02	0.00E+00	-10.2742521	3641.969	584.5873		
	3.639	0.506	0	-0.227	3548.025	3.88E+02	0.00E+00	58.3063808	3993.932	96.59287		
	1.702	9.081	-2.164	0	1659.45	6.96E+03	-1.47E+03	0	7146.105	14.31509		
	3.249	0.422	0	0.083	3167.775	3.23E+02	0.00E+00	-21.3190732	3469.712	1237.212		
	3.376	0.557	0	-0.031	3291.6	4.27E+02	0.00E+00	7.9625454	3726.229	490.1677		
	3.47	1.45	0	0.121	3383.25	1.11E+03	0.00E+00	-31.0796127	4462.883	1370.823	3831.70865	
	20.786	0.000123	-0.136	0	20266.35	9.42E-02	-9.24E+01	0	20174.09	38.01045		
										DH	657.0598299	
WATER GAS SHIFT												
623.15	-41											
	3.28	0.593	0	0.04	-1066	-8.88E+01	0.00E+00	6.9970655	-1147.78	-184.235		
	3.639	0.506	0	-0.227	-1182.675	-7.58E+01	0.00E+00	-39.7083467	-1298.14	-31.3953		
	1.702	9.081	-2.164	0	-553.15	-1.36E+03	1.55E+02	0	-1757.25	-3.52012		
	3.249	0.422	0	0.083	-1055.925	-6.32E+01	0.00E+00	14.5189109	-1104.58	-393.867		
	3.376	0.557	0	-0.031	-1097.2	-8.34E+01	0.00E+00	-5.42272576	-1186.01	-156.014		
	3.47	1.45	0	0.121	-1127.75	-2.17E+02	0.00E+00	21.1661231	-1323.67	-406.578	-1188.319702	
	20.786	0.000123	-0.136	0	-6755.45	-1.84E-02	9.77E+00	0	-6745.7	-12.7097		
623.15												
	3.28	0.593	0	0.04	1066	8.88E+01	0.00E+00	-6.9970655	1147.782	184.2351		
	3.639	0.506	0	-0.227	1182.675	7.58E+01	0.00E+00	39.7083467	1298.137	31.39533		
	1.702	9.081	-2.164	0	553.15	1.36E+03	-1.55E+02	0	1757.248	3.520124		
	3.249	0.422	0	0.083	1055.925	6.32E+01	0.00E+00	-14.5189109	1104.584	531.9046		
	3.376	0.557	0	-0.031	1097.2	8.34E+01	0.00E+00	5.42272576	1186.012	7.800711		
	3.47	1.45	0	0.121	1127.75	2.17E+02	0.00E+00	-21.1661231	1323.665	241.1625		
	5.457	1.045	0	-1.157	1773.525	1.56E+02	0.00E+00	202.39012	2132.363	266.4771	1279.205225	
	20.786	0.000123	-0.136	0	6755.45	1.84E-02	-9.77E+00	0	6745.7	12.70972		
										DH	-525.386651	

[illegible]

PREHEATER (After De Sulpurisation)															
C	K														
	Tin	Tout													
Cp			A	B	C	D									
			1	1.00E-03	0.000001	100000									
CH4	300	573.15	1.702	9.081	-2.164	0	936.1	4.24E+03	-8.86E+02	0	4286.044	0.016063657	572.4151		
H2S	850	1123.15	3.931	1.49	0	-0.232	2162.05	6.95E+02	0.00E+00	19.82187	2876.931	0.000496796	11.88277	584.2979	DH
PREHEATER (Before Secondary Reformer)															
C	K														
	Tin	Tout													
Cp			A	B	C	D									
			1	1.00E-03	0.000001	100000									
O2	25	298.15	3.639	0.506	0	-0.227	1728.525	1.29E+02	0.00E+00	46.77576	1904.044	0.005197899	82.2839		
N2	500	773.15	3.28	0.593	0	0.04	1558	1.51E+02	0.00E+00	-8.24243	1700.637	0.019306481	272.9762		
INERT			20.786	0.123	-0.136	0	9873.35	3.13E+01	-1.97E+01	0	9884.896	0.00022662	18.62435	373.8844	DH
LER (Before Water gas shift reaction)															
C	K														
	Tin	Tout													
Cp			A	B	C	D									
			1	1.00E-03	0.000001	100000									
N2	1000	1273.15	3.28	0.593	0	0.04	-2132	-3.65E+02	0.00E+00	3.277187	-2494.19	0.019306481	-400.352		
O2	350	623.15	3.639	0.506	0	-0.227	-2365.35	-3.12E+02	0.00E+00	-18.598	-2695.79	0.002908938	-65.1975		
CH4			1.702	9.081	-2.164	0	-1106.3	-5.60E+03	1.31E+03	0	-5388.86	0.000240943	-10.795		
H2			3.249	0.422	0	0.083	-2111.85	-2.60E+02	0.00E+00	6.800162	-2365.13	0.042888484	-843.345		
CO			3.376	0.557	0	-0.031	-2194.4	-3.43E+02	0.00E+00	-2.53982	-2540.22	0.015822135	-334.154		
H2O			3.47	1.45	0	0.121	-2255.5	-8.94E+02	0.00E+00	9.91349	-3139.22	0.036945023	-964.245		
INERT			20.786	0.123	-0.136	0	-13510.9	-7.58E+01	8.26E+01	0	-13504.1	0.00022662	-25.4434	-2643.53	DH

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